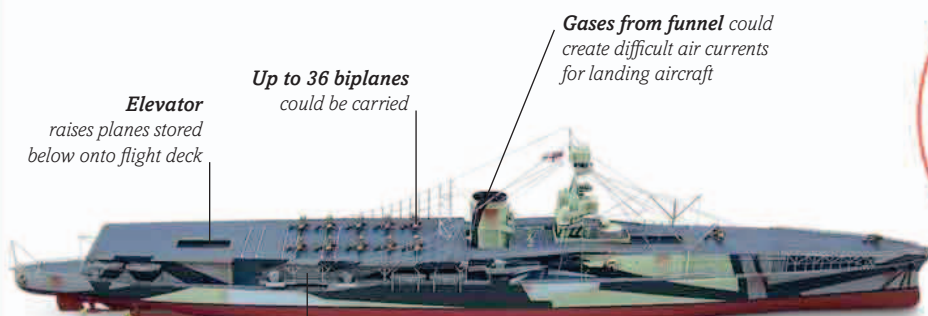




Aircraft carriers



Nuclear reactors can keep *USS George Washington* running for **18 years**, with no need to refuel!



786 ft 5 in (239.7 m) long

Up to 36 biplanes could be carried

Gases from funnel could create difficult air currents for landing aircraft

Elevator raises planes stored below onto flight deck

Hangar for aircraft storage

HMS Furious UK 1917

Missile launcher



Four propellers move the carrier at speeds up to 35 mph (56 km/h)

Akagi Japan 1927

855 ft 4 in (260.7 m) long



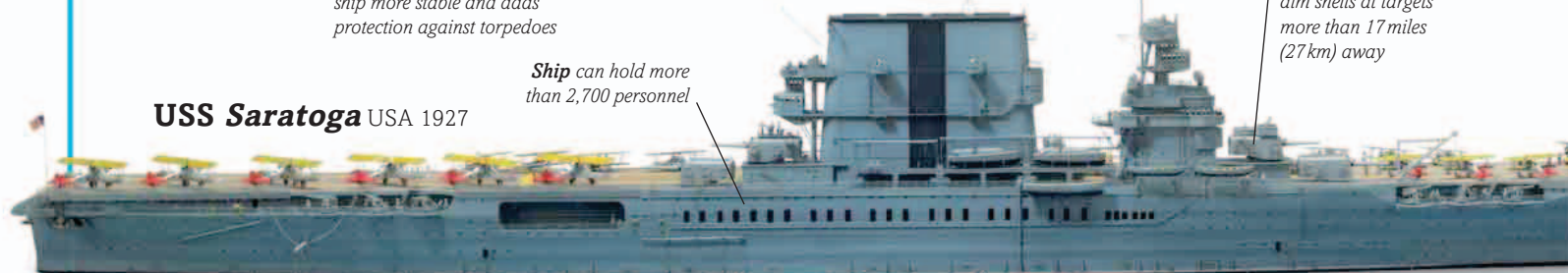
Hangar deck on two levels

Bulges in hull makes the ship more stable and adds protection against torpedoes

Quick-firing antiaircraft guns

Ship can hold more than 2,700 personnel

USS Saratoga USA 1927



Twin 8 in (20 cm) guns in turret can aim shells at targets more than 17 miles (27 km) away

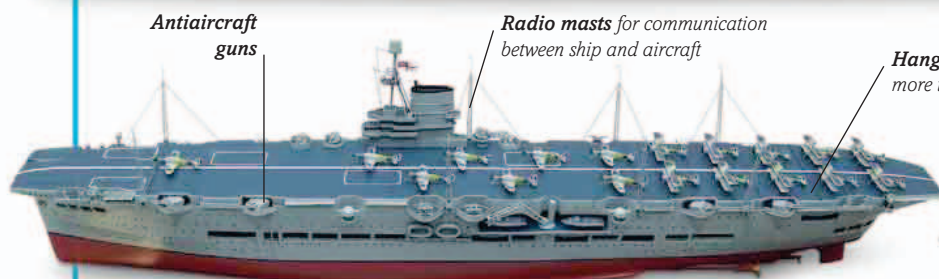
888 ft (270.7 m) long

Antiaircraft guns

Radio masts for communication between ship and aircraft

Hangers could hold more than 60 aircraft

Aircraft parked on armored flight deck



800 ft (243.8 m) long

HMS Ark Royal UK 1938

Flight deck ended in "round down" to reduce air turbulence for planes taking off

HMS Illustrious UK 1940

751 ft (229 m) long



As aircraft became important military weapons, ships that could act as floating airbases were designed. These aircraft carriers are huge vessels with a large, flat flight deck, from which helicopters and planes can take off and land.

Many early aircraft carriers, including the **USS Saratoga**, **HMS Furious**, and the **Akagi**, were initially designed as battle cruisers before being converted. The *Akagi* carried up to 66 aircraft, which took off from three flight decks, while the *Saratoga* could carry up to 78 planes. Specially